

Level Up

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(Don't Write anything in this Area)

(b) Critically examine the debate between Formalists and Substantivists.

(20 marks)

The debate between formalist and substantivist school of thought is regarding the nature of economic models that can be applied to primitive societies.

ORIGIN of debate

- (i) Malinowski's 'Argonauts of Western Pacific' (1922) noted the presence of kula exchange which assumed little economic significance.
- (ii) Marcel Mauss in 'The Gift' (1924) also noted presence of ceremonial exchange and called them "total prestations".
- (iii) Karl Polanyi in 'The Great Transformation' (1944) advanced their theory and started the substantivist school of thought.
- (iv) As a response, formalist school emerged in 2nd half of 20th century.

BASIC PREMISES

FORMALIST

Schneider, Harkovitz.

SUBSTANTIVIST

M. Sahlins, Dalton